

Blast from THE PAST

Narendra Modi turns the Supreme Court's order to probe his alleged role in the riots into a political battle

| By Uday Mahurkar |

Narendra Damodardas Modi has been on a roll. A star campaigner who can play with the mass mind, he has already addressed more than 300 rallies, more than any other leader in his party. He is the model chief minister who has turned his state into a byword for development. And for admirers, he is destined to play a bigger role beyond Gujarat. The communal savagery of 2002 was a distant story, and Modi has come a long, long way. Or, that was what he thought. The spectre of Gujarat 2002 has now returned to haunt the man who continues to concentrate the mind of India.

The Supreme Court has asked the Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing 10 specific riot cases to look into the role of Modi, 11 of his ministerial colleagues, police officers as well as bureaucrats. Suddenly, the moderniser has to defend himself against accusations of his Government's inaction or even alleged complicity in the 2002 riots. Sensing the uses of adversity, he is determined to make a best-selling slogan of victimhood—or even martyrdom—out of the apex court's order. He has got another bogeyman to rage against at his stump speeches.

And the political fallout was immediately visible. A section of the BJP workers, who were earlier unhappy with the distribution of tickets, got a booster when Modi went on to “expose” the “political conspiracy”

behind the order. Predictably, the latest CBI clean chit to the Bofors accused Ottavio Quattrocchi came handy. At a rally on the last day of campaigning in the state, he said: “It's a Congress conspiracy against me. Kapil Sibal had officially said in a television interview recently that I would go to jail for the 2002 episode. Congress might not agree but I am Bharat Mata's son. So, in Congress raj, it is jail for Bharat Mata's son and bail for Quattrocchi.” At another place he said: “As a valiant son of Gujarat, I am prepared to face jail, even the gallows. Between jail

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NARENDRA MODI, *Chief Minister*

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This public bravado apart, the Supreme Court order underlines the truth that the legacy of 2002 can take the sheen out of the moderniser who swears by development. The Congress has already called for the immediate resignation of the chief



minister. Moreover, the court order could make Modi's task of getting the American visa, which was denied to him in 2005, even more difficult. The SIT has to file its report within three months. If the report clears him completely, it will be Modi Unbound thereafter. If it implicates him or his administration, it will be used by his rivals—including those